

THE
**CROWNLESS
REALMS**

A WORLD FOR FANTASY CRUX 2

PLAYER PRIMER + GAMEMASTER GAZETTEER

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Candidate setting: This unpublished, noncanonical world uses Fantasy Crux 2's rules, Shaping, creature profiles, and equipment without new mechanics.

Player Primer

A realm held together by old roads and new bargains

Ninety-three years ago, Emperor Caldras IV entered the Hall of Measures to be crowned and never emerged. The ministers waiting outside heard the coronation bells ring once, backward. When they forced the bronze doors, the throne was empty, the imperial crown was ash, and every mirror in the hall reflected a different claimant.

The empire came apart by writ, siege, unpaid garrison, marriage, and quiet theft. Its roads, aqueducts, keeps, and sea walls still bind the continent. Seven great enchanted public works-the Crownworks-perform fragments of their old purposes. All seven are failing.

The successor realms have laws, grudges, and grandchildren, but none can dominate. Three noble houses claim the vanished throne. Free cities defend their charters. Elven, dwarven, goblin, orc, lizardfolk, merfolk, and pixie powers negotiate as states, not curiosities. Temples preach civic duty beneath the Seven Lamps, while philosophers quarrel over whether any god has ever answered them.

This is high magic as a ruined capital is wealthy: visible, inherited, local, narrow, and expensive. A village may have a boundary stone that turns grave-cold near undead and no one capable of repair. A Shaper may calm one river bend, then lack the PP to repeat it before

resting. The impossible does not make food, safe roads, Surgery, or honest officials commonplace.

Adventurers matter because they can go where armies cannot. A chartered company can cross a disputed border without starting a war, examine a Crownwork without admitting a claimant owns it, or recover an anchor before a rival learns it was missing.

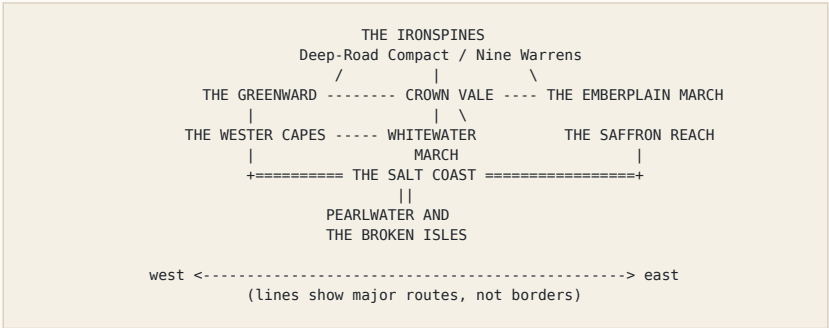
What everyone knows

- 1 **There is no crowned emperor.** Anyone who claims otherwise is making a political statement, committing treason somewhere, or both.
- 1 **The old infrastructure is dying.** The Crownroads crack, ward-stones go silent, and once-predictable gates open onto the wrong destinations. Failures are still rare enough to be alarming and common enough to support a profession.
- 1 **Magic is real and dangerous.** People know prayers, diagrams, songs, bargains, and battle gestures that produce effects. Only rare scholars recognize these practices as expressions of the same Techniques and Forms.
- 1 **A Tell can save your life.** Soldiers learn to recognize the copper taste, doubled shadow, ringing glass, luminous script, or other unavoidable sign of a Shaping. They may not know what is coming, but they know to break the Practice, seek cover, Counter, or run.
- 1 **A serious wound changes the plan.** A Wounded traveler needs Surgery or equivalent treatment before natural recovery. Wise companies identify healers.
- 1 **The roads are political.** A bridge toll, ferry seal, clan banner, or city charter may matter more than a sword. People who can read local authority survive longer.
- 1 **Nonhumans are neighbors and powers.** Every named people may hold lawful authority; species alone does not determine allegiance.

- 1 The gods are disputed, not forgotten.** The Synod runs hospitals, courts, schools, and cemeteries. Its prayers use the same Shaping limits; whether that proves divine favor is the oldest argument in the realms.

The shape of the realms

The usual campaign map covers the western two-thirds of the continent of Ordan and the adjoining Pearlwater. Roughly two-thirds of play lies on continental roads, farms, forests, uplands, and marches; the remaining third lies along three long coasts and among the Shard Isles.



Distances are intentionally large enough for weather, supply, and healing to matter. Land estimates below use a ten-hour day: 30 km for Marching or slow riding with animals and wagons, 50 km for Hiking or ordinary Riding, and the listed terrain multipliers. Hiking and fast Riding carry their normal Fatigue tests. Sea estimates use the ship rules: in normal conditions a vessel covers 20 miles per day per knot of Speed. Storms, calms, checkpoints, and damaged roads can turn any estimate into a hope.

Major route

Vellbridge to Crownseat

Distance and terrain

150 km of Crownroad

Expected passage

5 days Marching; 3 days Riding

Major route

Vellbridge to Leth Arain, Greenward

Distance and terrain

175 km; road, then 70% light woods

Expected passage

about 7 days Marching; 4-5 days Riding

Major route

Crownseat to Kar-Morun, Ironspines

Distance and terrain

210 km; road, then 70% rolling hills

Expected passage

about 8 days Marching; 5 days Riding

Major route

Crownseat to Banner Ford, Emberplain

Distance and terrain

240 km; mostly road and open trail

Expected passage

about 8 days Marching; 5 days Riding

Major route

Banner Ford to the Saffron Gate

Distance and terrain

180 km; 70% rolling dryland

Expected passage

about 9 days Marching; 6 days Riding

Major route

Vellbridge to Gull's Rest

Distance and terrain

42 km of maintained road

Expected passage

1½ days Marching; less than a day Riding

Major route

Gull's Rest to the Shard Isles

Distance and terrain

280 miles by sea

Expected passage

about 2½ days in a 6-knot sloop, 3½ in a 4-knot ship

Major route

Wester Capes to the Pearl Compact

Distance and terrain

420 miles by sea

Expected passage

about 3½ days in a 6-knot sloop, 5¼ in a 4-knot ship

These are clean-route figures, useful for planning rather than promises. A detour around a silent ward-stone, a day bargaining at a border, or one storm can matter more than mount quality.

Eight broad regions

Crown Vale

The former imperial heartland is a quilt of claimant estates, charter cities, temple holdings, and villages that still call themselves imperial because no one has told the tax rolls otherwise. Wheat fields and vineyards surround abandoned signal towers. Crownseat, the old capital, remains the largest city in the west: three governments occupy different districts, each issuing permits for the whole. The empty Hall of Measures is sealed behind six competing guard posts.

This is the realm of succession intrigue, forged writs, urban expeditions, and ruins under inhabited streets. Its danger wears livery. A company may be hired to escort a witness, then discover that every faction wants the witness alive for a different trial.

The Greenward

West of Crown Vale, forests swallow the old provincial boundary. The Verdant Court is an elven federation of grove-cities, human woodland cantons, dryad domains, and road abbeys. Its law distinguishes between land that may be owned, land that may only be tended, and land old enough to be consulted. Outsiders call this mysticism until a bridge is condemned by unanimous vote of engineers, villagers, and the naiad beneath it.

The Greenward is neither timeless nor united. Younger elves want roads reopened; old houses remember imperial logging levies; human charcoal towns fear elven courts will erase their charters. Heavy woodland halves ordinary travel rates.

The Ironspines and Nine Warrens

The northern mountains contain the dwarven cities of the Deep-Road Compact and the goblin commonwealth called the Nine Warrens. Their tunnels overlap like two legal arguments. Dwarves hold the monumental roads, ventilation towers, and deep bridges; goblin leagues hold side galleries, hot springs, mushroom caverns, and most of the trade that actually keeps miners fed.

The Compact and the Warrens have been allies, rivals, and besiegers within living memory. Both now face subsidence along the old imperial Deep Causeway. Surface lords covet their iron and engineers. Things sealed below the causeway test every new crack. Underground travel rewards survey, Mechanisms, light discipline, and the humility to retreat before a sound becomes a creature.

The Emberplain March

Eastward plains belong to the Iron Banner March, an orc-led confederation of clans, farm towns, veteran colonies, and mobile herding courts. The empire once paid the Banner to guard its frontier, then described the same people as raiders whenever payment failed. Modern orcs keep copies of both contracts.

Banner law is blunt, literate, and obsessed with witnessed obligation. A guest may be safer under an orc roof than in a claimant palace, but an oath-breaker can be hunted across three realms. Wyverns nest in the red mesas. Old battlefield dead rise when weather exposes imperial mass graves. The March offers cavalry war, contested water, clan politics, and courts where a scar may be admissible evidence.

The Saffron Reach

Beyond the eastern escarpment lies hot savanna, irrigated lowland, and salt desert governed by the Saffron Scale Throne. Its lizardfolk calendar-judges divide authority by season: flood magistrates rule canals, dry magistrates rule roads, and neither may lawfully command the other outside their months. Human and orc communities hold seats in the same courts, while caravan guilds exploit every transition.

Imperial maps label the Reach a conquered province. No surviving Scale record agrees. The region's buried reservoirs, crocodile waterways, giant-lizard caravans, and sunken observatories attract treasure hunters. Heat, thirst, poison, and the wrong season's warrant kill more reliably than monsters.

The Wester Capes

Cliff towns, fog islands, and wind-cut pasture stretch west of the Greenward. The League of Open Cities was born here when five ports bought their charters from three different claimants and dared any of them to admit the fraud. The League's merchant councils protect free passage, private contracts, and their own monopolies with equal conviction.

This is a place of smuggling coves, signal towers, shipyards, and old sea forts. Harpy nests and griffin aeries overlook shipping lanes. League captains know the Pearl Compact's pilots are worth more than another mast, but many resent paying merfolk tolls for reefs their grandfathers ignored.

The Salt Coast

South of Crown Vale, broad estuaries and tidal marshes hold mixed cities older than the empire. The Whitewater March, the recommended starting region, sits where a Crownroad crosses the river and runs to Gull's Rest. Farther east, Synod estates surround the Lantern Aqueduct; farther west, goblin salt factors and elven shipwrights share flood-prone wards.

The Tide Lock Crownwork once moderated the worst storm surges. It now sounds at low tide and sometimes closes when the water is high. Coastal campaigns combine court business with muddy boots: missing cargo, compromised levees, customs murders, wreck salvage, and villages that have one night to prepare for a sea serpent.

Pearlwater and the Shard Isles

The Pearlwater is governed as much below the surface as above it. The merfolk Pearl Compact controls reef passages, tidal anchorages, surface platforms, and air-filled halls built into sea caves. Merfolk breathe air and hold their breath underwater for 11 minutes; their settlements are engineered around breathing wells, sheltered chambers, and frequent access to the surface.

The Shard Isles contain independent barons, temple refuges, pirate republics, and the shattered observatories of the imperial storm fleet. Sea travel can be fast, but the margin between an intact ship and drowning is small. A strong wind may double a day's passage; a storm can strip Structure from a vessel before a sword leaves its scabbard.

Peoples, cultures, and languages

Species does not assign a Culture skill. Choose the society that raised the character. An elf fostered in Vellbridge may take Culture (Whitewater) and Language (Crown Speech); a human envoy raised at Leth Arain may take Culture (Verdant Court) and Language (Ilyr). The names below are ready-to-use character origins.

Origin

Vale charterfolk

Common peoples

Mostly human; every people represented

Culture and own Language

Culture (Crown Vale); Language (Crown Speech)

Character texture

Clerks, retainers, artisans, tenant farmers, ruined gentry

Origin

Whitewater marchers

Common peoples

Human, goblin, dwarf, pixie

Culture and own Language

Culture (Whitewater); Language (River Crown)

Character texture

Barge crews, wardens, smugglers, bridge engineers

Origin

Araini groves

Common peoples

Mostly elf and human

Culture and own Language

Culture (Verdant Court); Language (Ilyr)

Character texture

Foresters, advocates, hunters, patient political heirs

Origin

Moruni holds

Common peoples

Mostly dwarf

Culture and own Language

Culture (Deep-Road Compact); Language (Karic)

Character texture

Miners, masons, debt witnesses, surface factors

Origin

Ninefold commonwealth

Common peoples

Mostly goblin

Culture and own Language

Culture (Nine Warrens); Language (Kesh)

Character texture

Couriers, mechanism-workers, hot-spring farmers, negotiators

Origin

Banner clans

Common peoples

Mostly orc; many human

Culture and own Language

Culture (Iron Banner); Language (Varkesh)

Character texture

Riders, oath-keepers, veterans, mobile judges

Origin

Saffron courts

Common peoples

Mostly lizardfolk; human and orc minorities

Culture and own Language

Culture (Saffron Scale); Language (Tessarak)

Character texture

Canal keepers, calendar lawyers, caravan guards, astronomers

Origin

Pearl houses

Common peoples

Mostly merfolk; mixed surface clients

Culture and own Language

Culture (Pearl Compact); Language (Pelagic)

Character texture

Pilots, reef wardens, divers, treaty brokers

Origin

Thistledown relays

Common peoples

Mostly pixie

Culture and own Language

Culture (Thistledown Post); Language (Briarlilt)

Character texture

Fliers, weather readers, cipher clerks, neutral messengers

Humans are numerous but politically divided. Their advantage is not a single empire-building culture; it is that no border can plausibly call them foreign as a whole. Elves of the Araini groves are long-lived forest citizens, not secluded spectators. Dwarves of the Moruni holds combine clan inheritance with elected engineering councils. Goblins made the Nine Warrens into a commercial commonwealth because surviving between larger powers required reliable rules. Orcs of the Banner prize strength, but define it as the ability to carry an obligation when conditions turn hostile. Lizardfolk organize public life around water, heat, and seasonal authority. Merfolk make maritime sovereignty possible through pilots, reefs, and air-linked coastal architecture. Pixies are physically small, politically protected, and very difficult to prevent from delivering bad news.

Use the existing fantasy-race guidance and creature profiles when a player chooses a nonhuman character. Dwarf and elf player packages are already specified. Goblin, orc, and lizardfolk require the same profile-to-player procedure and Gamemaster approval; use the existing Lizardman profile for lizardfolk. Merfolk and pixies can create pronounced movement, Size, and access differences; include them only when the campaign can support those differences rather than quietly ignoring them.

Religion under the Seven Lamps

The Synod teaches that seven divine Lamps illuminate mortal life: **Hearth**, which keeps; **Gate**, which judges passage; **Scale**, which weighs; **Rose**, which binds love and grief; **Hammer**, which gives labor dignity; **Storm**, which tests; and **Star**, which guides the dead. Most temples contain seven niches and emphasize two or three. Names and genders change by region.

The gods do not appear in public and settle disputes. No universally accepted scripture contains a statement that cannot be translated three ways. Yet Synod hospitals work, oaths sworn at Gate altars carry social force, and some priests Shape through prayer with astonishing skill. Skeptics say disciplined ritual is sufficient. Believers answer that discipline is how mortals become audible.

Temple miracles use ordinary Shaping. A priest still needs known cells, a Practice, PP, and a successful test. Their Tell is observable, their work can be Countered or Dispelled, and overreach can cause Backlash. The Synod's achievement is institutional: it trains healers, maintains supplies, records who can treat a Major Wound, and stations them along important roads.

Ancestor observances, elven land consultations, dwarven memorial guilds, Banner oath fires, Saffron solar courts, and Pearlwater tide vigils coexist with Synod worship. None requires a new magic system. A spirit may be encountered using an existing profile, while a rite performed by a Shaper uses the normal Technique and Form cells.

Shaping in daily life

People usually learn a rite before they learn a theory. A Whitewater ferryman might know that Surveyor Kelm taps three brass nails before sensing a damaged route. A Moruni miner knows the blue grit around a dwarf stone-reader's hands means to stop hammering. Neither needs the terms **Scry·Paths** or **Scry·Earth/Stone**. Those exact cells are the rules truth and the language of a small cross-tradition scholarly network.

Most settled districts can name one Novice or Apprentice Shaper. Their useful magic is minor or specialist in scale and bounded by PP. Veterans are recruited by name, and Experts draw the attention of courts. Masters belong to legend, terrifying old beings, or campaigns in which a lasting price can redraw history.

Common traditions include:

Tradition

Crown Survey

Typical Practice and Tell

Recite a measured route while aligning brass tools; nearby straight edges double in the Tell

Favored cells

Scry·Paths, **Ward·Paths**, **Alter·Earth/Stone**

Tradition

Synod service

Typical Practice and Tell

Spoken litany with lamp, cord, or washing; the Tell casts seven faint shadows

Favored cells

Alter·Flesh, **Ward·Spirit**, **Scry·Spirit**

Tradition

Moruni stonecraft

Typical Practice and Tell

Hammer rhythm and traced load lines; dust rises in geometric ridges

Favored cells

Scry·Earth/Stone, Bend·Earth/Stone, Ward·Earth/Stone

Tradition

Araini husbandry

Typical Practice and Tell

Breath, sung names, and living focus; leaves turn their pale sides outward

Favored cells

Alter·Flesh, Scry·Flesh, Ward·Flesh

Tradition

Banner oathwork

Typical Practice and Tell

Declare witness and consequence over iron; every voice nearby carries a second beat

Favored cells

Bend·Fate, Ward·Mind, Unmake·Force/Motion

Tradition

Ninefold wayfinding

Typical Practice and Tell

Knotted thread, rapid notation, and counted corners; nearby corners seem briefly nearer

Favored cells

Scry·Paths, Scry·Fate, Conjure·Mind

These are preferences, not bonus lists or exclusive schools. Every Shaper defines their own observable, interruptible Practice and unavoidable Tell. Learning Shaping costs 20 IP, grants a specialty and two exact cells containing it, and requires initiation or discovery. Institutions control teaching because instruction is scarce and politically useful, not because the rules demand a license.

The Crownworks make the world feel more magical than its living population could support. Each is a permanent supernatural enchantment with vulnerable physical or spiritual anchors. They can be sensed and, through their anchors, Dispelled. Their makers paid prices no current archive records cleanly. Repairing one is not a Craft roll with glowing tools; it is the subject of expeditions, rituals, negotiation, and possibly another lasting price.

The Whitewater March: starting region

The Whitewater March is prosperous by Crownless standards: grain barges run on schedule, its road watch is usually paid, and three powers disagree over its ownership without currently besieging it. It gives a new company three useful scales of play.

- 1 **The city ring:** Vellbridge offers same-day investigations, guild feuds, temple politics, burglaries, court hearings, and trouble around the Crownwork.
- 1 **The frontier ring:** four satellite settlements lie within one or two days, close enough for urgent travel and far enough for weather, Wounds, and pursuit to matter.
- 1 **The expedition ring:** Crownseat, the Greenward, Ironspines, and Shard Isles require multi-day planning, supply, border terms, and a safe way home.

Vellbridge

Vellbridge stands on both banks of the Whitewater where the imperial Crownroad crosses the **White Span**, one of the seven Crownworks. The Span is pale stone, 800 metres from gate to gate, though travelers walking it count fewer steps than its survey length should require. It once remained dry, lit, and structurally sound in any weather. Now its lamps dim in sequence, distances lurch by a few paces, and one parapet weeps salt water at noon.

Thirty thousand residents live among tiled counting houses, crowded river wards, old barracks, shrines, mills, and the claimant manors on Measure Hill. The elected March Council governs markets and drains. House Veyran appoints the road warden. The League of Open Cities holds the river customs contract. The Synod claims the bridge chapel. None can act without the others accusing it of preparing an annexation.

Useful places include:

- 1 **The Brazen Mule**, an outfitter near South Gate, sells ordinary core-rule weapons, armour, general gear, trail supplies, and access to draft animals at prosperous-city availability. Proprietor Hesta Coil refuses to call debt charity but extends it to companies who bring wounded hirelings home.
- 1 **The House of the Rose Lamp** maintains Healing Kits, safe beds, trained healers, and Surgery. Senior surgeon Doctor Samel Ancor is not a Shaper and considers this professionally important. Sister Irra Vale can provide **Alter·Flesh** at Intensity 3+ as Surgery when present and able to pay its PP.
- 1 **Third Measure Hall** is a reduced Crown Survey office. It offers a possible Shaping initiation after a candidate assists a real survey, demonstrates restraint around an unstable anchor, and accepts continuing obligations. It is not initiation on demand.
- 1 **The Bent Copper** is a respectable bathhouse above an unrespectable archive. Its goblin manager, “Aunt” Neris Skell, is the

best underworld contact in the March for smuggling, forged travel seals, stolen correspondence, and rumors. She sells introductions, not loyalty.

- 1 **Thistledown Station Seven** occupies the old western bell tower. Pixie relays fly sealed message tubes between weather shelters. Normal service is physical, tiring, and delayed by storms or predators. A few trained couriers know **Bend·Paths** for short, rules-legal relocations; there is no instantaneous long-range post. Postmaster Pella Underleaf treats neutrality as sacred and unpaid postage as a personal insult.
- 1 **The Charter House** records small adventuring companies. A charter grants no immunity, but it names legal partners, distributes salvage shares, and lets authorities hire a company without recognizing a rival state's soldiers.

Four satellite settlements

Rillmarket, 28 km northwest on good road, collects grain, horses, and news. Its timber palisade encloses three inns and a weekly claimant court. A dry culvert beneath the market leads toward an imperial storehouse no map admits exists.

Blackglass, 24 km east through light brush, grew around a dark-stone quarry. Dwarven engineers inspect its dangerous faces; goblin crews work its best mechanisms. The quarry exposed an imperial acoustic conduit linked to the White Span's anchor casing in Vellbridge, and all work is officially paused.

Hollow Ward, 36 km north on the Crownroad, is a half-inhabited imperial fort. The March Watch holds its gate, Banner traders hold its caravan yard, and something opens the sealed infirmary from inside on moonless nights.

Gull's Rest, 42 km south on maintained road and river, is the March's seaport. Its tidal basin supports fishing boats, river barges, one-masted couriers, and larger League ships. Pearl Compact pilots

operate an air-filled treaty hall cut into the breakwater. A merfolk visitor can reach every chamber by flooded ramp and surface frequently; landfolk enter through the upper door.

Ready character premises

- 1 The new charter:** Each character has bought, inherited, or worked off one share in the same Vellbridge company. The March Council offers its first contract: determine why a bridge lamp went dark without damaging the Span or letting a claimant seize the investigation.
- 2 The missing survey:** Each character is tied to a member of Survey Team Hallow, missing after descending beneath the White Span. The Survey calls it a routine inspection; a fourth member surfaced alone and sold Aunt Neris a copied notebook.
- 3 The hard road home:** The characters survived the same disastrous caravan journey. They owe Doctor Ancor for Surgery, Hesta Coil for equipment, and one another for getting back alive. A lawful salvage warrant offers a way to clear the debt-if three other parties have not bought the same warrant.

Powers you can approach

Power

The Claimant Houses

Public face

Three dynasties-Veyran, Ordel, and Castaine-offer law, patronage, and incompatible versions of legitimacy.

Power

League of Open Cities

Public face

Merchant republics defend charters, open shipping, and profitable independence.

Power

Crown Survey

Public face

Neutral engineers and Shapers inspect imperial roads, records, and Crownworks.

Power

Synod of Seven Lamps

Public face

Temples provide courts, hospitals, burial, schooling, and an organized moral vocabulary.

Power

Deep-Road Compact

Public face

Dwarven holds maintain northern engineering, mines, and hard-won treaty roads.

Power

Verdant Court

Public face

Elven-led grove polities negotiate for living landscapes and woodland communities.

Power

Nine Warrens League

Public face

Goblin communes and factors move food, mechanisms, credit, and information underground.

Power

Iron Banner March

Public face

Orc-led clans and towns guard the east under a web of witnessed oaths.

Power

Saffron Scale Throne

Public face

Lizardfolk seasonal courts govern canals, caravans, and the southeastern approaches.

Power

Pearl Compact

Public face

Merfolk houses pilot ships, mark reefs, and enforce maritime treaties.

Power

Thistledown Post

Public face

Pixie relays carry authenticated messages while claiming strict political neutrality.

No power is wholly benevolent or secretly monstrous. Each can be employer, ally, obstacle, or antagonist. Intrigue works best when the company needs two factions that cannot be seen helping one another.

Gamemaster Gazetteer

Everything below reveals setting secrets, active conspiracies, site contents, and an advancing crisis. Players should stop here unless the group prefers open information.

Running the Crownless tone

The setting works when splendor and vulnerability appear together. Show an impossible bridge shortening a road, then reveal its cracked anchor. Let a temple Shaper stop Bleeding, then ask who has the Healing Kit and safe room for the next patient. Keep dragons, spirits, portals, and enchantments visible while preserving the importance of maps, witnesses, armour, food, sailors, and retreat.

Combat should rarely be the only honest solution. Telegraph threats: carcasses before a wyvern, unnatural silence before undead, scales before a sea serpent, warped stone before a golem. Negotiation, preparation, avoidance, and escape are successes. A named political enemy usually needs better skills, equipment, position, and allies-not an unwieldy crowd.

The principal campaign question is not “Who deserves the crown?” It is “What should people preserve when the system that built their world cannot be trusted?” Claimants, republics, old peoples, and new institutions answer differently.

What Shaping reliably does

The metaphysics remain unresolved, but the observable process is consistent.

- 1 A Shaper learns an exact relationship between one Technique and one Form-a cell-not an unlimited school of effects.

- 2 The Practice makes the intended relationship coherent and interruptible. Its words, diagrams, tools, gestures, prayers, or trance differ by tradition.
- 3 The Shaper's Power Points pay for imposing that relationship. The formula $\text{sum of outcome Intensities} + \text{Range} + \text{Duration} + \text{Reach} + \text{adjustments} = \text{Magnitude}$ measures the burden of the complete Shaping, not how ornate its description sounds.
- 4 The Tell is reality's unavoidable local response around Shaper and ranged target or area. Concealing it requires Veiled and raises Magnitude.
- 5 Safe Magnitude reflects expertise. Overreach can fail with PP loss and Backlash; a fumble does so even within safety. This is why institutions prize conservative practitioners and why interrupting a Practice is effective.
- 6 Continuing effects occupy active capacity: total active Magnitude cannot exceed permanent, unmodified POW. Indefinite effects commit maximum PP. No tradition escapes these limits by changing vocabulary.
- 7 Permanent supernatural enchantments need vulnerable physical or spiritual anchors and remain active and Dispellable through them. Permanent mundane creation and completed permanent transformations follow their own rule.

Rituals distribute preparation and, where permitted, pledged PP; they do not increase a Shaper's maximum Intensity. Any dial at 5 is Mythic and exacts a lasting price. These facts are known to the few scholars able to compare traditions. They are also why Crownwork repair cannot become a routine civic expense.

Three theories, none confirmed

The First Accord says reality is a covenant made of permissions, names, and reciprocal obligations. A Technique is a kind of legal act; a Form identifies the party addressed; Practice states the petition; PP is earnest payment; and the Tell is public witness. Its strongest evidence is Fate, Spirit, thresholds, and the strange importance of declared outcomes. Banner oath-workers, many elves, and legal theologians favor it. Its weakness is indifferent matter: fire and stone respond to a correct cell when no plausible will hears the bargain.

The Lattice says existence has an underlying geometry. Cells are valid operations upon ten families of structure. Practice constructs the proof, Magnitude describes its length, PP supplies the work, and Backlash is a failed operation resolving through the nearest available structure. Crown Surveyors, Moruni engineers, and Ninefold analysts favor it. The Lattice predicts spatial and material Shapings well, but becomes metaphorical when explaining grief, souls, vows, and why two equally correct diagrams can have different Tells.

Divine Writ says the Seven Lamps authored the permitted operations of the world. Shaping is possible because creation remains legible; Practice is an act of reading, PP is mortal breath, and Tell is the reflected light of authorship. The Synod favors it, though not every priest does. It explains the consistency of cells across cultures and the high price of boundary-breaking Mythic work. It cannot explain why blasphemers, undead minds, and practitioners who deny every god can Shape as effectively as believers.

Do not reveal a winner. Evidence discovered in play should strengthen one theory while creating a harder question. Even the imperial makers disagreed: Crownwork plans contain contractual language, geometric proofs, and hymns in the same hand.

The seven failing Crownworks

Each Crownwork is a complex of one or more permanent, anchored Shapings. Its observed functions should be expressed through existing cells when exact resolution matters. Repairs may stabilize mundane masonry without magic; true restoration needs access to anchors, capable Shapers, an appropriate ritual, and possibly a lasting price. Nothing here grants a new spell or item.

Crownwork

The White Span

Public function and present failure

Shortens and protects the Vellbridge crossing through Paths and structural effects; distances now lurch and salt water appears

Concealed anchor problem

One of nine brass route-rods was replaced with a convincing mundane copy

Crownwork

The Deep Causeway

Public function and present failure

Stabilizes the most important Ironspine road with Earth/Stone workings; collapses advance from below

Concealed anchor problem

Its foundation anchor is intact but being deliberately moved a handspan at a time

Crownwork

The Tide Lock

Public function and present failure

Directs harbor water and denies the worst surges; it now closes at dangerous tides

Concealed anchor problem

Its treaty pearl remains seated, but the Pearl Compact has legally withdrawn the consent it represented

Crownwork

The Lantern Aqueduct

Public function and present failure

Carries and protects clean water into southern Crown Vale; sickness now follows particular channels

Concealed anchor problem

Its fixed Reach ends at the old boundary; three expanded districts draw through unprotected connectors

Crownwork

The Orchard Bell

Public function and present failure

Protects a belt of orchards through layered works; outer sections fail each winter

Concealed anchor problem

Blight kills outer root anchors, producing discrete failures

Crownwork

The Storm Needle

Public function and present failure

Series approaching weather and once signaled the Wester Capes; it now gives precise false warnings

Concealed anchor problem

Someone sustains a Veiled indefinite Shaping that biases its mundane selector gears

Crownwork

The Gate of Names

Public function and present failure

Watches and denies passage to marked imperial corpses beneath Crownseat; dead officials now appear above

Concealed anchor problem

Grave registers used as linked anchors are being stolen and sold as succession evidence

The shared crisis is coordination, not a single magical infection. The Crownworks have distinct, often legitimate weaknesses. The Pale Cabinet, a compartment inside the Office of Continuance, worsens them so age looks like the only cause and emergency rule like the only cure.

Faction dossiers

Each entry gives enough pressure to make the faction useful immediately. Favored cells describe trained members, not every member, and the Tell is an example for that tradition rather than a free effect.

The Claimant Houses

- 1 **Public purpose:** Houses Veyran, Ordel, and Castaine each claim to preserve lawful succession until a true coronation can occur.
- 1 **Concealed objective:** The houses jointly fund the Office of Continuance, whose jurists and engineers prepare lawful plans for an interregnum. Only its compartmentalized Pale Cabinet engineers Crownwork failures; house leaders believe that wing is testing repair and emergency procedures.
- 1 **Internal fracture:** Veyran would expose sabotage and repair the works even at cost to its claim. Ordel wants evidence published as part of an elective settlement. Castaine wants quiet control of the works before any disclosure.
- 1 **Resources and relations:** Estates, courts, soldiers, archives, and marriage ties. They compete openly, court the Synod, resent the League, and hire the Survey they undermine.
- 1 **Leader shorthand:** Lady Maud Veyran, austere veteran and true believer; Prince Oren Ordel, charming constitutional schemer; Duchess Sal Castaine, patient creditor with impeccable manners.
- 1 **Shaping:** Court adepts favor **Scry·Mind** and **Bend·Fate**; their Tell makes spoken titles echo from the wrong direction.
- 1 **Current operation:** Rival house agents seek the White Span rod: Veyran to return it, Ordel to publish it, Castaine to impound it, and the Cabinet to destroy it.
- 1 **What they ask:** Prove a rival tampered with the bridge, escort a genealogist, or retrieve a “private family relic.”
- 1 **If ignored:** The Cabinet manufactures a bridge panic, and a claimant garrison enters Vellbridge in the sincere belief that it is emergency protection.

League of Open Cities

- 1 **Public purpose:** Defend municipal charters, open trade, navigable water, and courts that enforce contracts across borders.

- 1 **Concealed objective:** Convert failing Crownworks into a toll-funded League trust, making private creditors the practical heirs of empire.
- 1 **Internal fracture:** Smaller cities need collective protection; the five founding ports intend to retain controlling votes.
- 1 **Resources and relations:** Ships, money, warehouses, advocates, and spies disguised as factors. The League works with goblin and merfolk traders, opposes claimant control, and treats the Survey as an acquisition target.
- 1 **Leader shorthand:** First Factor Ysabet Dorn, plainspoken, funny, and never surprised by a debt.
- 1 **Shaping:** Navigators favor **Scry·Water/Ice** and **Ward·Paths**; their Tell beads moisture along every nearby written line.
- 1 **Current operation:** Buy Blackglass quarry debts and the rights beneath them.
- 1 **What they ask:** Protect an auditor, break a smuggling monopoly, or obtain a defensible copy of an imperial easement.
- 1 **If ignored:** The League forecloses on Blackglass during the crisis and gains private access to the White Span's acoustic conduit.

Crown Survey

- 1 **Public purpose:** Inspect roads, bridges, archives, boundary stones, and Crownworks without recognizing any successor crown.
- 1 **Concealed objective:** Senior Surveyors believe the seven works form one distributed ritual. They suppress data that might prompt a claimant to attempt it before the pattern is understood.
- 1 **Internal fracture:** Field teams favor public warnings; the Central Measure values neutrality and fears panic more than secrecy.
- 1 **Resources and relations:** Maps, route seals, engineers, modest Shapers, and unrivaled institutional memory. Everyone needs the Survey and suspects it.

- 1 **Leader shorthand:** Chief Measurer Tal Orsic, exhausted dwarf, exacting mentor, willing to lie only in complete sentences.
- 1 **Shaping:** *Scry·Paths*, *Ward·Paths*, and *Scry·Earth/Stone*; the Tell doubles brass edges, while a successful Scry supplies any useful direction.
- 1 **Current operation:** Quietly recover Survey Team Hallow and its White Span readings.
- 1 **What they ask:** Guard a survey, enter an unsafe Crownwork, or carry sealed measurements outside official channels.
- 1 **If ignored:** Central Measure burns the compromising field archive, leaving the next repair attempt dangerously incomplete.

Synod of Seven Lamps

- 1 **Public purpose:** Operate temples, hospitals, burial grounds, arbitration, poor relief, and schools.
- 1 **Concealed objective:** Preserve institutional unity by proving all legitimate Shaping traditions descend from Divine Writ, even if inconvenient records must remain sealed.
- 1 **Internal fracture:** Hospital clergy value useful cooperation; doctrinal examiners see cross-tradition scholarship as theft from the gods.
- 1 **Resources and relations:** Public trust, healers, safe houses, records of births and deaths, and moral pressure. It courts claimants but depends on city funding and nonhuman practitioners.
- 1 **Leader shorthand:** Canon Prelate Jeren Sorn, gentle bedside presence, ruthless curator of doctrine.
- 1 **Shaping:** *Alter·Flesh*, *Ward·Spirit*, and *Scry·Spirit*; seven soft shadows radiate from practitioner and target.
- 1 **Current operation:** Move a recovered imperial hymn-proof from Vellbridge to the sealed library in Crownseat.
- 1 **What they ask:** Escort patients, investigate disturbed graves, or recover a stolen reliquary-anchor without scandal.

- 1 **If ignored:** Examiners blame heterodox Shapers for Crownwork failures and restrict hospital cooperation with them.

Deep-Road Compact

- 1 **Public purpose:** Maintain dwarven holds, safe mining law, and the deep roads that support northern trade.
- 1 **Concealed objective:** Abandon one failing Causeway district and redirect its traffic through Compact-owned toll galleries before the evacuation becomes public.
- 1 **Internal fracture:** Engineers say the sacrifice is necessary; families in the condemned galleries have not been told.
- 1 **Resources and relations:** Heavy craft, disciplined guards, metal, stone records, and patient credit. The Compact needs Ninefold food and resents claimant mining concessions.
- 1 **Leader shorthand:** Speaker Droma Kel, warm host, cold structural realist.
- 1 **Shaping:** Bend·Earth/Stone, Ward·Earth/Stone, and Scry·Earth/Stone; the Tell lifts loose grit in parallel ridges; Scry reveals structural facts.
- 1 **Current operation:** Trace who is shifting the Deep Causeway foundation anchor without admitting the road may be lost.
- 1 **What they ask:** Enter an unstable gallery, escort evacuees discreetly, or prove a surface concession fraudulent.
- 1 **If ignored:** A preventable collapse kills residents and turns the Nine Warrens against the Compact.

Verdant Court

- 1 **Public purpose:** Defend the Greenward's peoples and living domains through negotiated stewardship.
- 1 **Concealed objective:** Allow the Orchard Bell to fail in order to end an imperial monoculture, then replace it with many smaller local agreements.

- 1 **Internal fracture:** Border towns depend on the enchanted orchards; deep-grove delegates consider that dependence a continuing occupation.
- 1 **Resources and relations:** Elven archers, foresters, long memories, living archives, and alliances with local nymphs. The Court distrusts claimants and works selectively with the Survey.
- 1 **Leader shorthand:** Advocate Serel Thorn, young by elven standards, impatient, and incapable of forgetting exact words.
- 1 **Shaping:** **Alter·Flesh**, **Scry·Flesh**, and **Ward·Flesh**; nearby leaves expose their pale undersides and breath smells of rain.
- 1 **Current operation:** Acquire blight samples before the Synod declares the dying root anchor a holy relic.
- 1 **What they ask:** Mediate with an anchored spirit, expose illegal logging, or move families before the protected orchards fail.
- 1 **If ignored:** The bell fails during a hard frost, destroying livelihoods and provoking anti-elven violence.

Nine Warrens League

- 1 **Public purpose:** Coordinate goblin communes, tunnel rights, mutual defence, food exchange, credit, and surface contracts.
- 1 **Concealed objective:** Assemble a complete copy of the imperial route archive and publish it, destroying every faction's monopoly on old access.
- 1 **Internal fracture:** Radical printers want immediate release; factors fear the maps reveal vulnerable homes and water supplies.
- 1 **Resources and relations:** Couriers, mechanisms, small credit, hidden routes, translators, and excellent gossip. The League trades with everyone and trusts Thistledown authentication most.
- 1 **Leader shorthand:** Convenor Ekkit Nine-Nails, cheerful negotiator, relentless note-taker, former smuggler who denies only the “former.”

- 1 **Shaping:** *Scry·Paths*, *Scry·Fate*, and *Conjure·Mind*; the Tell twitches knotted cords without direction and makes listeners taste mint.
- 1 **Current operation:** Buy Hallow's copied notebook from Aunt Neris before the Claimant Houses seize them.
- 1 **What they ask:** Carry a printing plate, survey a forgotten vent, or negotiate safe publication terms.
- 1 **If ignored:** Radicals publish an unredacted map; several sealed sites are looted and one warren is attacked.

Iron Banner March

- 1 **Public purpose:** Guard the eastern plains and enforce witnessed obligations among clans, towns, and allied peoples.
- 1 **Concealed objective:** Prove an imperial claimant ordered the old Red Field massacre, then use the evidence to cancel every surviving frontier oath.
- 1 **Internal fracture:** Settled magistrates need cross-border law; mobile clans believe the empire's successors deserve no bargain.
- 1 **Resources and relations:** Fast riders, veteran infantry, oral and written witnesses, herds, and frontier forts. The Banner respects Saffron courts and dislikes being treated as claimant cavalry.
- 1 **Leader shorthand:** Marshal Korva Ash-Tusk, deliberate orc jurist whose silences are mistaken for simplicity exactly once.
- 1 **Shaping:** *Bend·Fate*, *Ward·Mind*, and *Unmake·Force/Motion*; voices carry a second heartbeat and iron vibrates.
- 1 **Current operation:** Recover a Gate of Names register said to list the officer who ordered the massacre.
- 1 **What they ask:** Authenticate a document, parley with a restless battlefield spirit, or escort a witness through hostile estates.
- 1 **If ignored:** A radical clan crosses the border, giving a claimant grounds for war.

Saffron Scale Throne

- 1 **Public purpose:** Govern irrigation, roads, caravan law, and seasonal courts across the Reach.
- 1 **Concealed objective:** Divert the next flood to expose a buried imperial observatory before foreign expeditions reach it.
- 1 **Internal fracture:** Flood magistrates accept flooded farms as lawful cost; dry magistrates call the diversion an undeclared act of war.
- 1 **Resources and relations:** Canal labor, caravan tolls, astronomers, hot-country scouts, and disciplined palace guards. The Throne works with the Banner and competes with League caravans.
- 1 **Leader shorthand:** Calendar-Queen Tessara IX, precise lizardfolk sovereign whose authority will legally lapse at the first dry-season bell.
- 1 **Shaping:** **Bend·Water/Ice**, **Scry·Fate**, and **Ward·Fire**; reflected sunlight forms moving scale patterns.
- 1 **Current operation:** Obtain Storm Needle records needed to time the diversion.
- 1 **What they ask:** Steal no artifact-merely reach the observatory first, record it, and leave its anchors untouched.
- 1 **If ignored:** The court diverts water on incomplete predictions, causing avoidable displacement and a border dispute.

Pearl Compact

- 1 **Public purpose:** Mark reefs, provide pilots, rescue wrecks, and enforce agreements between surface ports and merfolk houses.
- 1 **Concealed objective:** Force renegotiation of the Tide Lock treaty by withdrawing the anchor pearl that once signified merfolk consent.
- 1 **Internal fracture:** Reef wardens want the Lock disabled; rescue houses fear the deaths and reprisals that failure will cause.

- 1 **Resources and relations:** Pilots, reef knowledge, surface stations, salvage claims, and fast swimmers within their breathing limits. The Compact needs the League's shipyards but contests its toll policy.
- 1 **Leader shorthand:** Tide-Speaker Oloa Sar, gracious merfolk diplomat, uncompromising about consent and privately terrified of storms.
- 1 **Shaping:** **Scry**·Water/Ice, **Bend**·Water/Ice, and **Ward**·Paths; salt crystals arrange into tidal arcs.
- 1 **Current operation:** Remove the repudiated treaty pearl without being accused of sabotaging the whole Crownwork.
- 1 **What they ask:** Carry messages between air halls, document illegal dredging, or escort a surface negotiator to a reef station.
- 1 **If ignored:** The Tide Lock closes against a surge, flooding the wrong side and turning a legal grievance into deaths.

Thistledown Post

- 1 **Public purpose:** Carry authenticated letters and small packets through a neutral relay network.
- 1 **Concealed objective:** Build a distributed duplicate of every Crownwork warning so no ruler can suppress a regional failure.
- 1 **Internal fracture:** Station masters support public safety; senior Keepers fear that copying sealed dispatches ends neutrality.
- 1 **Resources and relations:** Pixie flight, weather shelters, ciphers, witnesses, and trust. Every faction uses the Post; all assume someone else has compromised it.
- 1 **Leader shorthand:** Keeper Brindle Quill, elderly pixie logistician, courteous and absolutely willing to ground the network on principle.
- 1 **Shaping:** Rare trained couriers favor **Bend**·Air/Storm or **Bend**·Paths; floating thistledown forms a visible spiral. Most deliveries use wings.
- 1 **Current operation:** Verify seven contradictory messages that all carry valid Survey seals.

- 1 **What they ask:** Escort a grounded courier, inspect a relay shelter, or deliver one packet without using Post routes.
- 1 **If ignored:** Brindle suspends priority traffic. Faction reaction time slows, forged orders flourish, and isolated communities receive no warning.

Eight ready-to-run sites

Use existing creature profiles and ordinary NPC guidance. The sites provide positions, motives, and decisions rather than bespoke statistics.

1. The ninth rod chamber

A maintenance stair beneath the White Span descends through three eras of masonry. The lowest door opens only when approached from the “short” direction of the bridge; careful measurement or **Scry·Paths** reveals the discrepancy. Inside, eight brass route-rods hum around one dull replacement. Two gargoyles roost in ventilation hollows, attracted by vibration rather than loyal to a faction. Team Hallow's injured leader and two survivors hide beyond them with the real rod. A Castaine clerk supplied the replacement on Cale Rusk's restoration order, but it also bears a Ninefold archive mark. Removing or restoring anything without a full survey risks a spatial lurch. The immediate reward is the team and its evidence; the real choice is who may inspect the rod.

2. Hollow Ward infirmary

The sealed infirmary opens because its old service golem still follows an order to admit the wounded after sunset. It drags sleepers from the fort yard, treats them as imperial casualties, and prevents them leaving until discharged by an officer dead for a century. The rooms contain useful mundane medical stores, some spoiled, and the officer's seal in a cabinet behind the surgical theatre. The golem can be fought, avoided through shift records, or satisfied by presenting a valid chain of command. In the crypt lies an intelligent mummy-the former surgeon-who wants the golem stopped but refuses to surrender patient registers that implicate House Veyran in wartime experiments.

3. Blackglass undercut

The quarry's new face reveals a dark-glass acoustic conduit carrying vibration to the White Span's anchor casing 24 km away. Quarrying altered that physical resonance path, and workers stopped before a dangerous oscillation. League, Compact, and Ninefold crews occupy rival camps above. A giant spider in a warm side shaft is announced by drained carcasses and webbed tools. On the deepest brace, a stabilizing screw-jack has been mounted backward to widen the conduit with every vibration. Its serial matches an Office of Continuance loan signed by Pale Cabinet surveyor Cale Rusk. It proves deliberate interference, but not that any claimant leader authorized it. Reaching it needs Engineering, quiet movement, or agreement among three groups trying to “secure” the site.

4. The drowned tollhouse

At low tide outside Gull's Rest, the roof of an imperial customs fort breaks the surface. Its upper rooms are air-filled for only two hours. Lower corridors remain flooded, and neither landfolk nor air-breathing merfolk can explore them without planning around suffocation. A giant octopus shelters in the collapsed warehouse and defends eggs rather than treasure. A ledger records the treaty pearl's original delivery to the still-seated Tide Lock and a rejected legal procedure for removing it. Pearl Compact agents want the ledger; League wreckers claim the structure as salvage. A retreat timed before the tide is a clean victory. Being trapped turns an archive search into a survival problem.

5. Station Black Measure

This Deep Causeway station hangs over a vertical fault on iron chains. Its anchor platform has moved exactly a finger's width north during each of the last seven new moons. A solitary troll lives in the warm drainage tunnel. It has learned that striking the platform makes food-bearing inspectors arrive, so it repeats the action when hungry; the "sabotage" is opportunistic rather than political. Killing it is hazardous in tight dark space and its Regeneration is telegraphed by recovered footprints after bloody encounters. Diverting drainage, feeding and relocating it, or sealing its access can save the road. Compact officials prefer a sabotage narrative that justifies their planned evacuation.

6. The root crypt of the Orchard Bell

The Bell hangs from a vast living root beneath a roofless abbey. Blight has made the root brittle, while an anchored dryad bound to an older tree insists the imperial orchard must die. Synod pilgrims have tied hundreds of petitions to the Bell, obscuring its physical anchor and adding fire risk. The blight is mundane and treatable if discovered early; the political disease is harder. Orchard families will accept smaller local protections only if the Court recognizes their land claims. The dryad can identify the original graft and negotiate, but will fight anyone who cuts the elder root. A hag in nearby limestone caves secretly encourages all sides and can only range beyond its domain at night.

7. The Storm Needle

The Needle rises from a Wester Cape accessible by a causeway at low tide. Its weather chamber still observes accurately. League Keeper Jessa Kelm sustains a Veiled indefinite Shaping that biases the mundane selector gears; the committed PP and active Magnitude remain hers, and the effect can be sensed and Dispelled directly. She meant to wreck a rival's ships, then learned the Pale Cabinet was choosing targets. Harpies on the outer balconies bargain for food and safe nesting rights. As a real storm approaches, the party must pursue Jessa, Dispel the sabotage, or operate the signal lanterns before the causeway floods.

8. The Observatory of Two Noons

Floodwater in the Saffron Reach reveals a brass dome only at midday. A mirrored shaft records old storm cycles. A basilisk nests where the twin sunbeams warm its clutch and canal vermin provide prey. Carved warning animals flank the opening, and unwounded vermin lie dead nearby. Bronze sight-baffles protect a cool north gallery, and bait can draw it into the outer sun court while an iris closes behind it. It will not pursue past the cold flood stair unless cornered, providing a safe withdrawal. Saffron astronomers want observations, a claimant expedition wants a portable mirror, and Banner jurists want a massacre order in the same cabinet. A bad salvage attempt could collapse the structural anchor.

Threat palette

Threat and profile

Imperial dead: skeleton, zombie, ghoul, ghost, or mummy

Warning, motive, and alternatives

Broken grave seals, old uniforms, and names scraped from rolls. Some guard instructions, some hunger, and some want testimony. Restore a register, satisfy an order, or retreat into ground they cannot cross. The Gate of Names and claimant archives connect them to politics.

Threat and profile

Road gargoyles: gargoyle

Warning, motive, and alternatives

Stone chips below empty parapets and missing rooftop animals. They hunt from height and value warm nesting sites. Offer livestock, deny a landing route, or move during poor flying weather. Survey structures give them excellent terrain.

Threat and profile**Fault troll:** troll**Warning, motive, and alternatives**

Blood trails that return uphill and crude food caches. It wants food and a defensible warm den. Fire suppresses Regeneration, but redirection or relocation is safer. Compact secrecy worsens encounters.

Threat and profile**Emberplain wyverns:** wyvern**Warning, motive, and alternatives**

Dropped bones, shadows over mesas, and silent herd animals. They protect nests and hunt isolated mounts. Detour, lure them away, or bargain with Banner nest-watchers for routes.

Threat and profile**Cave hag:** hag**Warning, motive, and alternatives**

Repeated rumors in different voices, missing lamps, and bargains offered after sunset. It manipulates desire and returns to its anchor when destroyed. Learn the domain, survive until daylight, or bargain at a price the party can actually pay.

Threat and profile**Reef hunter:** giant octopus or sea serpent**Warning, motive, and alternatives**

Empty fishing grounds, sucker marks, or a wake against the wind. An octopus may guard eggs; a serpent wants prey and a sea cavern. Pearl pilots know avoidance routes. Fighting in water or from a damaged deck should feel desperate.

Threat and profile

The Ash Chancellor: vampire

Warning, motive, and alternatives

Exsanguinated officials, invitations delivered at dusk, and records only the dead should recall. It seeks influence and Blood Reserve, not random slaughter. Daylight, exposure, and denial of isolated victims create leverage. The Pale Cabinet trades information with it.

Threat and profile

Varkesh-of-Cinders: dragon

Warning, motive, and alternatives

Scorched boundary stones, frightened griffins, and formal messages burned into fields. The dragon considers itself an imperial creditor and wants recognition of an ancient debt. Conversation is the expected first encounter; direct battle is a warning that the campaign has reached legendary stakes.

Complications on the road

Roll or choose when a journey needs a consequential turn. A complication should change choices rather than merely consume time.

1D6

1

Land complication

A Crownroad milestone points correctly but its distance is wrong by 20 km. Following it saves time only if the party identifies a brief Paths distortion before it ends.

1D6

2

Land complication

A claimant patrol and Banner riders both demand custody of the same exhausted witness. Neither wants a fight in front of neutral travelers.

1D6

3

Land complication

A cart has overturned on the only firm ground. Its Wounded driver needs Surgery, its cargo bears false League seals, and rain is turning the verge to mud.

1D6

4

Land complication

Thistledown couriers have grounded because giant hawks hunt the relay. They offer authenticated news in exchange for escort to the next shelter.

1D6

5

Land complication

A silent ward-stone and scattered bones warn that undead crossed here recently. The shorter road passes a sealed grave field; the detour adds a day.

1D6

6

Land complication

A village closes its gate before a predicted storm that never appears. The false warning matches the Storm Needle's signal code, and locals suspect the party brought it.

Complications at sea

Use normal Sailing, storm, Structure, drowning, and ship-combat rules when they become relevant. Magic does not grant a free hull repair, safe breath, or successful manoeuvre.

1D6

1

Maritime complication

A Pearl pilot signals an uncharted reef and demands the captain stop. The chart is current; the League customs seal authorizing passage is not.

1D6

2

Maritime complication

A strong favorable wind could double progress, but carries smoke from an island settlement. Keeping speed means passing people who may need rescue.

1D6

3

Maritime complication

The sea becomes glass-calm. A distant sloop still moves, suggesting oars, Shaping, or a current absent beneath the party's hull.

1D6

4

Maritime complication

A storm warning arrives from Thistledown and a contradictory all-clear from the Storm Needle. Sailing around costs a day; choosing wrong risks 2D6 Structure damage.

1D6

5

Maritime complication

Salvagers cling to wreckage and claim their ship was rammed. Taking them aboard exceeds comfortable quarters and brings a violent contract dispute.

1D6

6

Maritime complication

Something large circles below without attacking. The crew wants weapons ready; the merfolk envoy insists it is driving the ship away from a sea-serpent cavern.

Twelve rumors

1D12

1

Rumor

The emperor still lives inside the Hall of Measures.

Truth

Unproven. Every scrying attempt reaches a different trace or none.

1D12

2

Rumor

Team Hallow stole the White Span's route-rod.

Truth

Misleading. They recovered it after discovering the copy.

1D12

3

Rumor

Aunt Neris sells every secret twice.

Truth

False by her own rule: she sells it once and sells the silence separately.

1D12

4

Rumor

Merfolk sabotage is making the Tide Lock fail.

Truth

Partly true. The Pearl Compact withdrew consent from the still-seated anchor, but neither removed it nor intended the dangerous response.

1D12

5

Rumor

The Deep Causeway moves north each month.

Truth

True by a finger's width at Station Black Measure.

1D12

6

Rumor

The Orchard Bell stopped protecting elven farms first.

Truth

False. Outer root anchors fail by location, not ancestry or allegiance.

1D12

7

Rumor

A claimant can be crowned if all seven works sound together.

Truth

Unknown. Survey records suggest a distributed ritual, not its outcome.

1D12

8

Rumor

The Synod keeps a hymn that is also a Crownwork diagram.

Truth

True. It supports all three major Shaping theories and proves none.

1D12

9

Rumor

The Nine Warrens possess tunnels into the imperial throne room.

Truth

Technically false; they possess a map to a sealed service route beneath it.

1D12

10

Rumor

Varkesh-of-Cinders ate the last imperial treasurer.

Truth

True, but only after the treasurer attempted to default on a witnessed bargain.

1D12

11

Rumor

Pixie postmasters read private letters.

Truth

Usually false. Current Keepers are copying only authenticated Crownwork warnings, which is still a breach.

1D12

12

Rumor

The Crownwork failures share one curse.

Truth

False. A single conspiracy exploits seven different weaknesses so they appear related.

Six opening adventures

The lamp that went dark

During evening traffic, one White Span lamp extinguishes and every person on the bridge hears the coronation bell. The March Council charts the party to keep the crossing open, find the cause, and avoid claimant occupation. Witnesses saw Survey Team Hallow descend below; a Castaine agent offers money to recover a “stolen rod”; Thistledown carries a forged evacuation order. The ninth rod chamber provides danger and proof. Success means choosing who receives the rod, the original field notes, and the public explanation.

Five hours to Gull's Rest

A storm warning reaches Vellbridge while riders report the Tide Lock closed at high water. A fast ride can reach the port before the surge but risks Fatigue for rider and mount; a slower force arrives too late. At Gull's Rest, Pearl envoys and League officials are seconds from violence. The party can open mundane spillways, carry terms into the treaty hall, or reach the Lock's accessible anchor. The crisis tests movement, negotiation, and whether anyone spends scarce PP before the true storm arrives.

The patients of Hollow Ward

Three people vanish from a caravan yard; one crawls back with neat bandages and an imperial discharge token. The fort commander wants a quiet recovery before rumor empties the route. Inside, the service golem is dangerous but consistent, and the mummy surgeon knows more than the commander expects. Fighting may rescue the captives; solving the order can rescue them without destroying a surviving piece of public infrastructure. The registers create a longer Veyran plot.

A share in Blackglass

Hesta Coil accepts the party's debt payment in the form of a simple escort job: take League auditor Pell Dorr to Blackglass. Dwarven workers accuse Dorr of engineering foreclosure; goblin salvagers possess a better map; and a worker is missing below. The giant spider is a telegraphed physical danger, while sound transmission to the anchor makes careless combat risky. Recovering the worker, the sabotage evidence, and a lawful claim are three different objectives.

The letter with seven seals

Postmaster Pella has seven copies of one Survey warning, each authenticated and worded differently. She hires the party to carry them outside the relay network to Keeper Brindle. Claimant agents want one version destroyed. A goblin printer wants all seven. At a grounded relay, giant hawks threaten the pixies but can be driven off without a pitched fight. Comparing delivery times reveals that the forgeries originated inside Central Measure, not Thistledown.

Grave credit

A merchant pays the company to recover an ancestor's debt tablet from a flooded family crypt. The dead inside include a ghost seeking testimony and corporeal undead still denied passage by a damaged fragment of the Gate of Names. The tablet proves the merchant owns valuable land-and that the land was seized after the Red Field massacre. Claimant, Banner, and Synod interests emerge as soon as the party asks for translation. The adventure begins as salvage and ends as a choice about evidence.

The advancing crisis

Advance one step after a major failure, after two adventures in which the party ignores the Crownworks, or whenever the campaign needs a harder public problem. Do not erase victories: a repaired work remains stable, and its listed event becomes an attempted incident the characters can expose.

Step

1

Development

Forged Survey warnings spread. Thistledown slows priority post while it authenticates messages; every faction begins using private couriers.

Step

2

Development

The White Span lurches during market traffic. No one must die, but trade halts and a claimant offers troops “temporarily.”

Step

3

Development

The Tide Lock mishandles a surge while the Storm Needle sends a false all-clear. Coastal factions mobilize and blame one another.

Step

4

Development

Station Black Measure collapses unless previously secured. Compact secrecy and Ninefold publication turn engineering loss into civil unrest.

Step

5

Development

Gate of Names registers disappear in bulk. Imperial dead emerge in Crownseat carrying forged orders that recognize the Office of Continuance as temporary custodian.

Step

6

Development

The claimant houses announce a joint emergency council. Their leaders discover that the Pale Cabinet controls its procedures, witnesses, and undead guards; each now needs outsiders it can trust.

Step

7

Development

The Pale Cabinet attempts to make all seven Crownworks sound in one distributed ritual. Its leaders do not know whether this crowns a regent, restores an imperial command network, opens the Hall of Measures, or exacts a Mythic price from the realm. The party's alliances and preserved anchors determine what options exist.

The final step is a convergence, not a predetermined apocalypse. Earlier relationships supply the options: Survey knowledge, Synod records, Ninefold maps, Compact engineering, living anchors, Banner witnesses, Saffron timing, Pearl consent, League logistics, claimant access, and Thistledown communication. No faction provides all of them. A dependable company can decide the future.

END OF THE CROWNLESS REALMS